

TOPIC 3: SOIL FORMATION AND CONSERVATION

1. Meaning and Formation of Soil

Soil is the top layer of the earth's surface in which plants grow. It forms from the weathering of rocks and the addition of organic matter (humus) over a long time. Climate, parent rock, organisms, topography and time affect soil formation.

2. Types of Soil and Characteristics

- **Sandy soil** – large particles, drains quickly, low water retention.
- **Clay soil** – fine particles, holds water, can be sticky and poorly drained.
- **Loamy soil** – mixture of sand, silt and clay; best for most plants.

3. Soil Erosion and Conservation

Erosion is the removal of topsoil by water, wind or human activity. Conservation practices include: planting cover crops and trees, terracing, contour ploughing, mulching, avoiding overgrazing, and proper drainage.

4. Importance of Soil

Soil supports plant growth, provides habitat for organisms, stores water and nutrients, and is the basis of agriculture and food security.

5. Summary

Soil forms slowly from rock and organic matter. Different types have different properties. Protecting soil from erosion is essential for life and farming.

End of Topic 3